

969HELDAVANEDIT

Also, this month on Travel Radio Australia, we're back in Amsterdam, Netherlands, where I chat with the owner of one of the best bed and breakfasts in the city, Prinsenkracht 969. Travel Radio, and this week we're broadcasting from Amsterdam in the Netherlands, and I have with me Helena van Gelder, yes? Is that how you say your name? Yeah, great. You pronounce it perfectly.

Now, Helena, you run the short stay apartments here at 969 Prinsenkracht, which is right in the middle of Amsterdam, just virtually a stone's throw from Rembrandt's plane. And welcome to the program, and tell us a bit about the building here and a bit of the history first of all. Yeah, thank you for inviting me.

The building is from 1690, 80, I'm not sure about that, it wasn't there at the moment. But it's a very old house, but that's why it's so lovely, because it's really Amsterdam on the canal, and the view that everybody knows from Amsterdam center. Yes, it's one of these lovely four-story black houses with the white windows, and it's just absolutely gorgeous.

And I used to actually live in one of these on the Constantijnhavenstraat, which has the attic room on the top as well, with the hook that comes out where you can actually pull the furniture in. That's interesting as well. Yeah, that's for foreign people, very strange what's hanging there over in the top, and for us it's quite normal, because otherwise we don't get stuff up when you want to change something, because the stairs are totally very small, and you can't get any furniture through the stairs, so you have to do it outside.

And that goes back to the 1600s, because then when these buildings were put together in the 1600s, you used to get taxed on the width of the building, didn't you? Yeah, so there were all kinds of ways to save money, so I can keep my money to myself. And also the ships had to get rid of their stuff that they were transporting to the canals in the past, and the Prinsengracht is the canal that was the one where really the work was done. So that's also, you see the other canals as Herengracht and Keizers, that are the luxury gachten, if you will say it in the centre now, the Prinsengracht is also a luxury canal.

Well, it's so close to where you're situated here, as I say, you're very close to the Rembrandtsplein, and virtually five minutes walk to the dam square, which is really easy to get to, and on a bike it's even quicker. Yeah, yeah, the bike for foreign people is maybe a bit of an adventure, just to avoid the other bikes, that's an adventure I think, for us it's normal. But you can do everything by walk for five or ten minutes away, I think you are on the Rijksmuseum and the dam square, everything is so close by that before you know it, you're there.

And if you don't want a bike, you can just simply walk there really easy. Yeah, I think it's more nice, because you see more of everything of Amsterdam, and it's more convenient, I think, for

foreign people. Now, 969, the service department you have here, and I wouldn't call it a service department, I'd call it more like a historic flat apartment, whatever, but it's very historic, and you feel, you've done it amazingly, it's the bottom floor of the house, and it also has a view out to the canal, and tell us a bit how that all came about.

I think, I'm living here now for myself for two years, and when I saw it, I think it was in the past in a store, it was not looking that nice, but I really wanted to keep the atmosphere there as the old house, but I also wanted to have it clean and modern, so I tried to make a mix of the old stuff, and the really antique what's standing in it, and very modern, so everything is clean, with respect for the building and its age. So we worked very hard, and I did the interior design myself, because I wanted to have the look throughs, I wanted to have the light coming from the front to the back, and the whole house has that, so also in the basement, as we call it, I think it worked out, I'm really proud of it. Yes, well I stayed here for two nights, and it is absolutely magnificent, it's very peaceful, very calming, and pretty funky too, because you've got the little bar area with the lighting underneath the bar, and it's really a very, very cool place, isn't it? Yeah, I like to have a twist, so really mix the new and the old stuff together, and I like to surprise people with little things, and well, we did manage, so I'm proud of it.

Yes, and I love little windows in there too, you've got the little doll's house type windows that have all been put in, and they're all original, aren't they? Yeah, they're coming from the attic, because I changed the attic, because I've got threesomes, and they also need a room, and they're getting bigger and bigger, so that part came out of the attic, and I thought, okay, I can use it in the basement to make there for the bathroom, the shower, and the toilet, so that's what I like, to get the elements inside the house, and just transport them there, where they really need it, be beautiful. And the point is that when people are staying in the basement area, they're completely separate from you, they don't have to see you at all, it's not like you're hovering around them, it's completely their own space. Yeah, that's what I love, that people are free as whatever they want, if they don't want to see me, it's okay, and there are also lots of people at the end that come upstairs and sit on the table and drink our wine or coffee or whatever, but that's for somebody for itself, they have to know it for themselves, they're totally free to go and to do whatever they want, but if they need anything, they can come upstairs and I can tell them how to find a way, or give them the shoe polish or whatever, and the whole household is running upstairs, so we're there.

And 969, it's called that, and how do people find you on the internet? I've got my own website, and it's www.prinsengracht969.nl No, it's fantastic, and I really appreciate the stay here, and as I say, if you're coming to Amsterdam and you want somewhere which is really, really central, and really accessible and beautifully historic, in a proper historic 1600s house, Prinsengracht 969 is really, really the great place to stay. And Helena, thank you very much for being with us at On Air World Travel Radio this weekend, and can you say hello to people, or a welcome in Dutch for us, to the house here? First, thank you for the interview, it's really lovely, and thank you for the compliment. When you are coming in Amsterdam, then we say, hallo, fijn dat je er bent, en wees

welkom.

Wonderful, thank you very much Helena. You're so welcome, thank you. Well, that's about it for this month, and the final episode of Travel Radio Australia for 2024.

We look forward to providing you with some fantastic new destinations in 2025. Our thanks this year to Sennheiser Audio for providing sound equipment for our interviews around the world, Travelodge UK, Norse Airlines International, and all our partners and contributing journalists. And of course, our interviewees in the Netherlands, UK, Europe, Asia, Scandinavia, USA, and of course, in Australia, New Zealand.

I also wish to thank Ashley Gibbons of the International Travel Writers Alliance for helping with contacts for the program. Also, thanks to Travel Radio Australia's founder, Rens Veers, for allowing me to present the program from now on. Join us again next time when we bring you stories from around this wonderful planet Earth.

Until then, safe travels, and have a lovely Christmas and happy New Year from Travel Radio Australia.